Bhagat Singh's grandmother, Jai Kaur, gave him the delightfully endearing name of 'Bhagonwala' (or the 'blessed one') upon his birth. She was delirious with joy. Her grandson was arriving in this world just as Ajit Singh and Swaran Singh were also making their way back home from prison. Who could have blamed her for her ecstatic utterance, '*Yah beta bhagon-wale hai*' ('This child is the bearer of good tidings for us'). Nor would it have been subsequently surprising to see him being formally invested with the name 'Bhagat Singh' (the 'devoted one') when the time came. Jai Kaur could not have imagined it, but Bhagat Singh in his short life would live up to both these names. He would do so even as he grew up to be a practising atheist and even as the shadow of the hangman's noose swayed before him. He would do so for his country and for his countrymen. For them, 'Bhagat' the 'Bhagonwala' would sacrifice his life and do so spectacularly.

In 1917, at the age of ten, Bhagat Singh found himself in Lahore. His father had decided to relocate to that great city in search of work. The family left Chak No. 105, Lyallpur Banga. They trekked a distance of some 250 km in a rickety cavalcade before ending up in Nawankot on the outskirts of Lahore. By then, Bhagat Singh had already passed his Class IV examinations at his village school. The value of education had early been ingrained in him. In the first letter, written at the age of eleven to his grandfather Arjan Singh, who was still living in their ancestral village of Khatkar Kalan, Bhagat Singh is seen to be writing joyously in Urdu on 22 July 1918 to say how he has 'passed comfortably' in the subjects of English and Sanskrit in Class VI. [3] The second letter discovered, also written to his grandfather in Urdu, again emphasizes the importance of education in his life. This time he is aged twelve, and he writes that 'I have passed in all the subjects in the half-yearly exams' although 'many students have failed the Maths paper'. [4] Armed with his early school success, Bhagat Singh was able to cheerfully enter DAV School upon his arrival in Lahore. He was the first Sikh boy to do so, because Sikh boys invariably went to the Khalsa schools, their own religious institutions, where they participated in daily Sikh prayers in the morning. In Bhagat Singh's case, it was not the Sikh